TSA 2013

Critical Thinking

Questions taken from the TSA Oxford 2013 Section 1 question paper

Questions	Total marks	Time limit
25	25	45 minutes

Instructions

- You have **45 minutes** to answer all **25 questions**.
- Each question is worth **one mark**. There are no penalties for incorrect answers, so attempt every question.
- Each question has five options, A to E. Choose the one option you consider correct.
- Calculators are **not** permitted. You may use this paper for rough working.
- Questions are numbered 1 to 25 for this set. The number in brackets shows the question's number in the original TSA 2013 paper, e.g. **1 (Q3)**.

How the time limit was set

The time limit follows the TARA Critical Thinking module (22 questions in 40 minutes), scaled to the 25 questions in this set: 25 × 40 ÷ 22 = 45.45 minutes, rounded to the nearest minute (45 minutes).

Score: _____ / 25

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1 (Q1) This week a controversial chef is urging the great British public to sample a fabulous new meat. But instead of a buying bonanza the chef's comments have provoked outrage because the meat in question is horse. Even the staunchest meat-eaters are up in arms. Says a rival chef: 'I would never eat horse meat and would never serve it to my customers. It's not part of our food culture. It's unthinkable.' But aren't we being just the teeniest bit irrational? After all, in France and Belgium, two of our closest neighbours, there are whole shelves of horse meat alongside the beef and chicken. Here we eat lamb and pig, duck, even deer, ostrich and kangaroo. If we eat these, what is logically different about horse? Nothing.

Which one of the following most closely expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A There is no logical difference between lamb or beef and horse.

B Eating horse meat in Britain is unthinkable.

C The British should follow the example of France and Belgium.

D The British response to eating horse meat is a little irrational.

E Meat-eaters have no good reason for objecting to horse.

2 (Q3) The most popular theory about the origin of the Moon is that it was formed from debris breaking off the Earth in a planetary collision 4.5 billion years ago. If this were true, the Moon would be made of the same material as is found on Earth. Examination of Moon rocks shows this to be the case, although there is little iron in Moon rocks. However, this can be explained because, according to the theory, the material that formed the Moon would have come from the Earth's crust, not its iron-rich core. Thus we should accept the theory as true.

Which one of the following identifies the flaw in the above argument?

A The popularity of a theory is not what determines its truth.

B Evidence that is inconsistent with a theory proves that the theory is false.

C The explanation offered in the passage is not consistent with the theory.

D Evidence that confirms a theory's predictions does not prove that the theory is true.

E A theory that is not consistent with the facts should be rejected, not modified.

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3 (Q4) The International Code of Zoological Nomenclature states that the earliest recorded scientific name for an organism becomes the official name. This seems fair, but the system is flawed. Textbooks show the sequence of fossil ancestors of the modern horse as: *Pliohippus, Merychippus, Mesohippus* and the first horse ancestor *Hyracotherium.* The last of these looks out of place. *Hyracotherium* was once, more sensibly, called *Eohippus*; this descriptive name means "dawn horse". The suffix *-hippus* (horse) is consistent with others in the list. *Eohippus* also sounds pleasant. The name was changed when it was discovered that a fossil fragment that had been named *Hyracotherium* was really from the same animal that had, until then, been called *Eohippus*.

Which one of the following conclusions is best supported by the passage above?

A Common sense is not a major factor in scientific naming decisions.

B A system of naming organisms based on the date the name was first registered is not the most appropriate.

C The rules of the International Code of Zoological Nomenclature do not always produce the most sensible name for animals.

D The name of *Hyracotherium* should be changed back to *Eohippus*.

E The rules of the International Code of Zoological Nomenclature need to be changed to allow for common sense.

4 (Q5) At Everthorpe Prison in Yorkshire, prisoners made no attempt to escape using ladders placed against the outside walls by drug dealers and prostitutes plying their trades. A prison officer spokesperson said that this was because the authorities had made prisons too comfortable and thus failed to deter criminals. A large number of released prisoners quickly reoffended and returned to prison, where they had all the comforts of home: a television in each cell, breakfast in bed, a wage and cash bonuses for good behaviour.

Which one of the following is an implicit assumption upon which the spokesperson's argument rests?

A Prisoners would not reoffend if prisons were less comfortable.

B Many criminals are habitual offenders.

C Not all prisoners are interested in drugs or prostitutes.

D The conditions inside prisons are determined by the prison officers.

E Reoffending rates have recently risen.

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5 (Q9) The recent campaign to reduce the number of people who drive while over the legal alcohol limit was very successful. But reducing it further is going to be difficult without addressing one of the main problems: people in rural areas have no choice, in the absence of public transport, but to use their cars. People who live in towns and cities can use buses, trains or readily available taxis if they want to go out for a drink. Furthermore, they don't have to go far to find pubs and clubs. Unless the Government wants the level of drink-driving to increase, it needs to ensure that far more pubs and clubs are built in rural areas.

Which one of the following, if true, would most strengthen the above argument?

A The legal alcohol limit for drivers is likely to be lowered in the near future.

B The public have been made much more aware of the dangers of drink-driving.

C Many pubs in rural areas are closing because of the reduced numbers of customers.

D The population of rural areas is predicted to increase over the next twenty years.

E The police concentrate their drink-driving campaign in towns and cities.

6 (Q10) Another pair of British media personalities have announced their separation. Both are well-paid personalities who profit enormously from the publicity they attract from their behaviour. Media personalities like them usually employ agents who can generate publicity, arrange well-paid personal appearances and sell stories and photo shoots to glossy magazines. These agents probably generate more income for some media personalities than their original activity, such as singing. Therefore it's clear that talent is no longer rewarded.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the above argument?

A These personalities may not be talented.

B Many performers may be rewarded for their own original talent as well.

C Agents generate a large amount of income for their clients.

D Agents may be destroying talent by their actions.

E Personalities do not have to choose to employ agents.

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7 (Q11) Films are expensive to produce and must take a significant amount of money at the box office to cover costs before any profit is made. Thus filmmakers are primarily interested in making a film that will appeal to a large number of people and so make a lot of profit. This often leads to the production of superficial, violent films that attract a large audience. Therefore, the Government should invest in the film industry. If it did that, filmmakers would not need to be motivated entirely by the aim for profit.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A The Government should invest in the film industry.

B Filmmakers need to ensure that their films will attract large audiences.

C Government investment in the film industry would reduce the need to aim for profit.

D The output of the film industry contains too many violent films.

E Aiming solely for profit leads to the production of superficial, violent films.

8 (Q15) Those in favour of coursework contributing to A-Level grades say that this is much fairer than assessment by exam only, as it means that students who are willing to work hard but who perform poorly in exams will have a better chance of doing well. However, this arrangement currently allows far more opportunity for cheating, casting doubt on its fairness. For example, there is a growing market for customised essays, available (for a fee) via the Internet. At the moment the only deterrent is a teacher's vigilance, but while teachers might identify work that seems atypical for individual students, they won't necessarily detect when, for example, a student has had an unacceptable amount of help from family or friends.

Which one of the following conclusions is best supported by the passage above?

A Assessment by coursework is not necessarily fairer than assessment by examination.

B The opportunities for cheating in coursework mean that A-Levels should be assessed by exams only.

C Traditional examinations are still the fairest way of grading A-Level students.

D There is no entirely fair way of assessing students at A-Level.

E Examinations do not assess how hard a student has worked.

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9 (Q16) Largely because of the influence of celebrity TV chefs and increased customer demand, many supermarkets have recently enlarged the amount of game (e.g. rabbits, pheasants and venison) in their meat sections. Factory farming is seen as cruel to the animals involved. Rabbit meat, in particular, is selling well as it is tastier than chicken and is cheaper than beef or pork. Game is also low in fat and cholesterol. If people are really concerned about animal welfare they should take advantage of the increased availability of game in the supermarkets. They will also be getting a nutritious and cheap diet.

Which of the following best expresses the underlying assumption in the above argument?

A Supermarkets want to improve their animal welfare image.

B The influence of celebrity chefs on shoppers cannot be underestimated.

C No game meat is produced using factory farming methods.

D Cheapness does not necessarily provide good value.

E Supermarkets always respond to customer demands.

10 (Q17) The production of standard disposable nappies from petrochemicals is wholly unsustainable. It is estimated that, while in disposable nappies, a baby will generate two tonnes of used nappies which will end up in landfill. Washable nappies have a significantly reduced environmental impact at production and at eventual disposal. Landfill sites are already in short supply, with recycling programmes aiming to reduce waste. However, if the Government wants to meet its sustainability targets it must do more to increase the use of washable nappies.

Which one of the following, if true, would most strengthen the above argument?

A The washing process of nappies involves further energy consumption.

B Some disposable nappies are made of natural polymers and are compostable.

C Most disposable nappies would take in excess of 500 years to bio-degrade in landfill conditions.

D Several local authorities have incentive programmes to encourage parents to choose washable over disposable nappies.

E By 2014 all local authorities must offer doorstep recycling and many already offer composting bins and appliance collection.

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11 (Q21) In recent years there has been a great deal of media attention focused on the private lives of politicians and world leaders, with particular attention paid to their personal relationships. There are those who suggest that this attention is unwarranted because only their professional abilities are important to their political role. This attitude fails to consider that the public have little insight into the day-to-day lives of world leaders and, indeed, few points of reference. Personal lives offer common ground. In democratic states leaders are elected based on how the public perceive them, and private lives can offer an insight into an individual's values. The personal aspects of a politician's life should continue to be reported if the electorate find it important.

Which one of the following, if true, most strengthens the above argument?

A All those in the public eye are subjected to media attention.

B Some politicians have high profile affairs.

C Attention on their private lives can cause leaders to lose their focus.

D Many of the public are very interested in the family lives of sports personalities.

E Most politicians claim to be respectable and honest in all aspects of their lives.

12 (Q22) Criminals often give themselves away by their lifestyle. My neighbour is a criminal because he bought and is living in a very expensive house, which I know he could not afford as he is officially working only in a poorly paid job.

Which one of the following most clearly parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A The cat keeps bringing mice into the house. He never eats them, so I assume he hunts them either because that is his instinct or for pleasure.

B It is impossible to write more than four pages in half an hour. You have just handed in seven pages of writing. You must, therefore, have spent longer than half an hour on it.

C The bank was extremely well guarded and robbing it would require very careful planning. The thieves who broke in yesterday must have spent months planning every detail of the crime.

D All my friends save money through the year and then go on holiday. I am saving every month, so I think I should be able to go on holiday soon.

E If the police want to identify criminals they need to watch how they are spending their money. They do want to catch them, so they watch out for people buying cars or houses they cannot legally afford.

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13 (Q23) There is often concern about the large quantities of money earned by top singers. It could be argued that there are many ways in which this money could be spent that would be beneficial to a large number of people. However, these people are receiving high earnings because they are the best at what they do and those who are better than others at what they do should be rewarded.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle underlying the argument above?

A To become a doctor requires a much longer course of study than other professions; therefore, doctors should receive a higher rate of pay than members of those other professions.

B When making the decision about who should be accepted onto the course, the bottom third of the applicants based on the results were eliminated immediately.

C Since efficiency is the most important aspect of the work, the end of year bonus was awarded to the member of staff who had made the best use of time over the year.

D When deciding on the member of staff to be promoted, the director of the company looked at the records of the applicants and chose the one who had done the most overtime in the past year.

E The prize for the best film was decided by taking the one that made the most money at the box office in its opening week.

14 (Q27) There is a naive view that the problem of rapid population growth can be effectively solved if enough money is invested in family planning services. But it is no accident that the world's highest population growth rates are in poverty-stricken sub-Saharan Africa. Child mortality in this region remains stubbornly high, so it makes sense for women to have lots of children to ensure that at least one son survives into their old age. Children are also economic necessities for peasant families engaged in traditional agriculture; in many systems the larger the family, the more land is allocated to it. It follows that only by reducing the demand for large families through economic development can the problem of overpopulation be solved.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A The need for economic development is greatest in sub-Saharan Africa.

B The demand for large families is mainly caused by high child mortality.

C The main consequence of a lack of economic development is overpopulation.

D Overpopulation can be properly tackled only by economic development.

E To believe that family planning services can reduce population growth is to be naive.

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15 (Q28) It is clear that telepathy is not possible because, if it were, people would be able to transfer their thoughts to each other for important purposes – for example, passing an examination. But this does not happen. The only supposed demonstrations of telepathy are about trivial matters.

Which one of the following arguments has the same logical structure as the above argument?

A It is obvious that humans cannot travel through time. No one has ever done this, except in novels and films, and we know that these are fiction.

B If humans were descended from apes, they would have some of the same patterns of behaviour. There are some patterns of behaviour common to humans and apes. So humans are descended from apes.

C If hypnotism could cure illnesses, we would not have to rely on drugs. But hypnotism cannot cure illness. So we do have to rely on drugs.

D It is evident that human life is the most intelligent form of life on Earth, because humans can exploit other life forms for their own purposes, and that is exactly what the most intelligent life form would have to be able to do.

E There is no evidence that intelligent life exists beyond our planet. If there were intelligent life elsewhere in the universe, we would by now have had clear evidence of its existence. So there is no intelligent life other than that on Earth.

16 (Q29) For the second year running the Silver Star Prize for art was awarded to a video artist, raising again the big question: What is great art? Many have condemned this year's choice on the grounds that a documentary-style video film cannot be considered as creative art at all in the way that, say, painting and sculpture can. The Silver Star jury, however, praised the 'emotional force of the work and its complexity beneath an apparently simple surface'. If they are right in this evaluation then clearly video is as much a medium for great art as any other form of expression.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the argument above?

A Any work with emotional force and complexity is capable of being great art.

B The decision of the jury to award the prize for a video was the right one.

C No-one can really answer the question: What is great art?

D This year's winning exhibit was deceptively simple.

E Painting and sculpture are the highest forms of creative art.

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17 (Q33) 'Organic food is no healthier than other produce, scientists claim.' This was the headline in an article published in 2009 in *The Independent*. It reported that a comprehensive review of 50 years of evidence showed no appreciable difference in nutrient levels between organic and conventional farm produce. If the review is correct shoppers will think twice about buying organic food, especially if the price difference remains significant. Only if people really do receive some health benefit in return for the extra money will the current upward trend in organic sales continue.

Which one of the following presents the strongest challenge to the above argument?

A Shoppers who read *The Independent* are more likely to buy organic produce than readers of other newspapers.

B Most shoppers take more notice of price than they do of nutritional benefits when choosing to buy.

C If the review is correct, shoppers will have received no health benefit in the past 50 years, yet organic sales have continued to rise.

D If organic food had more nutritional value than conventional farm produce, scientists would have found out long before now.

E If there is no appreciable difference in nutrient levels there is no advantage for shoppers in switching back to conventional produce.

18 (Q34) There is widespread dissatisfaction and disillusionment in Britain with politics and with politicians, who are seen as untrustworthy. Many of the electorate do not even bother to vote in a general election. In Switzerland democracy is more direct than in Britain, in the sense that many referendums take place, and many important political decisions are thus based directly on the votes of citizens rather than on those of their elected representatives. Surveys show that in those parts of Switzerland where more of these important decisions are made by referendum, the citizens are happier than in those areas where there is less opportunity to influence decisions. So if we were to adopt the Swiss system in Britain, the dissatisfied and disillusioned British electorate would be much happier.

Which one of the following identifies the flaw in the above argument?

A It assumes that most Swiss citizens vote in general elections.

B It assumes that there is only one reason why some Swiss citizens are happier.

C It assumes that British citizens would trust politicians if there were more referendums.

D It assumes that there is only one reason why the British are disillusioned with politics.

E It assumes that better policies emerge when important decisions are made by referendum.

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19 (Q35) Sound economics may underlie the Government's plans to put more prisons under private control, but the privatisation of prisons is nonetheless wrong. Although some countries observe basic human rights, they have the power to take away the liberty of individuals who break certain laws. This power is so far-reaching that only the State itself, acting through its officers, should be entrusted with it. Many prisoners have disturbed backgrounds and a contempt for authority, so exceptional disciplinary measures are needed to maintain order. The power to enforce such measures should not be left to private, profit-making organisations.

Which of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the argument above?

A The State has far-reaching powers and duties.

B The privatisation of prisons is wrong.

C Order in prisons often requires special disciplinary measures.

D Prison inmates often have disturbed backgrounds and a contempt for authority.

E Special disciplinary powers should not be entrusted to private organisations.

20 (Q39) Compare and contrast the initial responses of two 'major world powers' to the Haitian earthquake disaster. Within hours, the USA had sent in hospital and assault ships and an aircraft carrier with 19 helicopters, the 82nd Airborne division with 3,500 troops and hundreds of medical personnel. It put the country's small airport back on an operational footing. Meanwhile, across the Atlantic, the European Union (EU) geared itself up with a Brussels press conference led by its High Representative. A small group of bored-looking journalists in the Commission's lavishly appointed press room heard her stumbling through a prepared statement, in which she said that she had conveyed her 'condolences' to the UN Secretary-General, and pledged three million Euros in aid. The USA's willingness to act proves that it is the only genuine superpower.

Which one of the following, if true, would most weaken the above argument?

A Haiti is much closer to the USA than to the European Union.

B The European Union has as many men in its armed forces as the USA.

C Of the countries of the EU, only Great Britain and France possess the naval and airborne capacity for major overseas operations.

D The countries of the EU respond to this and all humanitarian crises individually because their armed forces are allied but not integrated.

E The response of the USA to the crisis was criticised by France as having a hidden agenda of wanting to increase its influence in Haiti.

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21 (Q40) One of the most catastrophic scenarios that could hit this planet would be a world without fish. Surely this is a matter for the UN to act on – and swiftly. Areas of ocean should be set aside as no-go zones for trawlers of any nationality, to enable our dwindling fish stocks to have somewhere to reproduce with impunity. We are told that farmed fish is just as good, but this is futile if the wild fish that are fed to the farmed fish disappear. This crisis should be moved right to the top of the global agenda.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A At present fish cannot reproduce safely in the wild.

B There is not enough publicity about the fishing crisis.

C Farmed fish does not taste as good as wild fish.

D Fish farming is impossible without wild fish as food.

E Foreign trawlers are responsible for dwindling fish stocks.

22 (Q41) Many rich countries protect their farming sectors with generous subsidies. It may be claimed that this policy can benefit countries in which people are starving or malnourished by encouraging farmers to produce more food than can be consumed in their own countries. But the policy is not in the best interests of poorer countries. Poor countries do not want charitable handouts – they want to develop the ability to feed their populations by their own efforts. If the amount spent on the European Commission's Common Agricultural Policy were invested in, say, irrigation schemes, that would transform the agriculture of many impoverished nations. This would surely be a better way to solve the problem of world hunger.

Which one of the following, if true, would most strengthen the above argument?

A Malnutrition is less likely to occur in countries with slow population growth.

B Wars and natural disasters such as floods are major causes of malnutrition.

C Much of the excess food produced by rich countries rots before it can be exported.

D Without subsidies to farmers in rich countries, the countryside would deteriorate.

E Agriculture in poor countries is less mechanised than in rich countries.

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23 (Q45) The criminal law, armed only with punishment, is only ever capable of controlling a tiny minority of criminals. Communities can exert control over the behaviour of most people in much more positive ways: through the disapproval of one's neighbours and fellow citizens and through a whole host of accepted social attitudes. Mass unemployment creates a large class of people who reject these attitudes and who are prepared to encourage, or at least tolerate, illegal ways of making a living, and hence has a profoundly subversive effect on society.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the argument?

A Large-scale unemployment subverts society.

B The criminal law controls the behaviour of only a tiny minority.

C Large-scale unemployment makes crime more acceptable.

D Controlling anti-social behaviour is best done by the community.

E Mass unemployment causes a rejection of accepted social attitudes.

24 (Q46) Our football team always loses the match if it's raining. They won last Saturday, so it can't have been raining.

Which of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A If you work part-time, you earn less than people who work full-time. I work full-time; therefore, I earn more than people who work part-time.

B My aunt is always happy if she's bought a new hat. She was happy today, so she must have bought a new hat.

C John always stays at home if there is snooker on TV. There is snooker on TV tonight, so John will stay at home.

D David always enjoys films if they have a big star in them. David didn't enjoy that film, so it can't have had a big star in it.

E My cat has gone missing because I forgot to feed her. My cat always goes missing if I forget to feed her.

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25 (Q47) When you have finished your meal at a restaurant and you get the bill, there is often a note at the bottom pointing out that the service charge is not included. This can easily lead to one of two reactions – leaving a tip because you feel it is what is expected, or not leaving a tip out of annoyance at the unsubtle request for more money. Neither of these is an appropriate response. The tip is a reward for providing good service. We should be rewarding those waiters who perform well and not just issuing tips as a matter of course.

Which one of the following illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A The company has made record profits this year, so all of the employees will be getting a bonus when they next receive their pay.

B When redundancies needed to be decided, Fred was laid off as his work had been particularly poor for the last few weeks.

C Tim got B grades in his exams rather than the C grades that he was predicted, so his parents bought him the bicycle that he had been asking for.

D The syndicate won the lottery last week and split the money equally between all of the members.

E As companies perform well their value on the stock exchange will increase.

END OF TEST

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